

Skills Summary

Picture Graphs and Bar Graphs — How to Read Them

Use this reference while completing your worksheet or when studying.

Skill 1 — One picture stands for more than one

Always find the key first. It is the little sentence under the graph that says what one picture is worth.

- Count the pictures in the row.
- Skip-count by the key number, once for each picture.
- Half a picture is worth half the key number.

Example: How many stickers did Sam get?

Sam    

Tia   

Key: one picture stands for 5 stickers

Step 1. The question asks for stickers, but the row shows pictures — so read the key and turn pictures into stickers before counting anything.

Step 2. Sam has 4 pictures. Skip-count by fives: 5, 10, 15, 20.

⇒ **20** stickers

Try it: How many stickers did Tia get? (Same key: one picture is 5.)

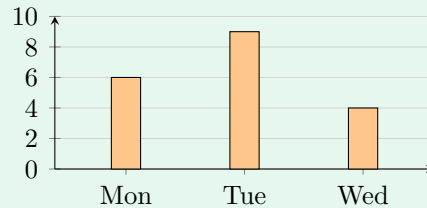
check: **15** stickers

Skill 2 — Bar graphs where the scale skips numbers

Look at the numbers up the side before you look at the bars. If they go 0, 2, 4, 6, ..., then one step is worth 2, not 1.

Put a finger on the top of the bar and slide straight across to the scale. If the bar stops *between* two numbers, it is halfway — take the number in the middle.

Example: How many cars on Tuesday?



Step 1. The scale counts by twos, so the height of a bar is not the number of steps — read the label the bar reaches, and check whether it stops on a line or between two.

Step 2. Tuesday's bar stops between 8 and 10, exactly halfway, and halfway between 8 and 10 is 9.

⇒ 9 cars

Try it: How many cars on Monday? (Same graph, same scale.)

check: 6 cars

Skill 3 — How many more, and how many altogether

Read every bar you need first. Write the numbers down. Then do the arithmetic.

- “How many **more**?” → subtract the smaller from the bigger.
- “How many **altogether**?” → add all of them.
- Compare the *amounts*, never the number of pictures or the number of steps.

Example: Using the car graph above, how many more cars on Tuesday than on Wednesday?

Step 1. “How many more” means a subtraction, but the graph does not show the difference — so read both bars first and subtract the two numbers.

Step 2. Tuesday is 9 cars and Wednesday is 4 cars, so the difference is $9 - 4$.

⇒ 5 more cars

Try it: How many cars altogether on Monday, Tuesday and Wednesday?

check: 19 cars